

USED TO SHOOT after 10 pm when my parents were asleep. It was work during the day, YouTube at night. My sleep schedule was ruined, but one video changed everything.” Meet 28-year-old Gaurang Patel,

aka Matgonian, a Gen Z gamer with over 2 million followers. He quit his full-time job as a software engineer after his creator income surpassed his salary at the 700K-subscriber mark.

Gaurang isn't the only Zoomer who has pivoted to the social media content space. From beauty to gaming, young creators now drive a new labour market across sectors, as publishers, marketers, performers, analysts, founders, and increasingly, employers.

That's because Gen Z is truly the first generation to come of age on social media platforms. “In

212 | India, the creator landscape is undergoing a foundational shift where individuals are evolving into ‘Contentpreneurs’, the next-generation start-ups of the media and entertainment industry,” says Gunjan Soni, Managing Director, India, YouTube.

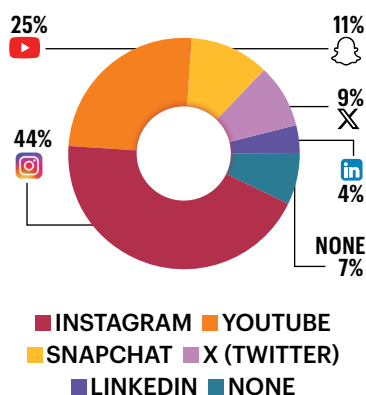
India's creator ecosystem is already a powerful economic force as 2–2.5 million creators influence an estimated \$350–400 billion in annual consumer spending, and this is projected to touch \$1 trillion by 2030, as per a 2025 BCG report.

The impact and potential of this ecosystem is clear and the entrepreneurial zeal mirrors evolving consumer behaviour. The BT-PRICE Gen Z Consumption Behaviour Survey reveals that 41% of Zoomers use the internet primarily for social media. They're not just consuming content there; they're acting on what they see. A good 22% of Gen Z respondents said they frequently



THE INFLUENCE ECOSYSTEM

Instagram leads among social media platforms in influencing Gen Z's purchase decisions



purchase products or services after seeing them on social media, while 38% do so occasionally. But there's a clear winner among the platforms: 44% said Instagram influences their purchase decisions, followed by YouTube at 25% and

Snapchat at 11%.

As a result, marketers no longer see creators as just add-ons to digital campaigns, but as credible drivers of consideration and purchase. Akansha Baliga, Marketing Lead for skincare brand Plum, says, “Reach is just a hygiene metric for us. The real signal sits in the comments; you can tell who watched the content till the end, - who's asking genuine questions, and who's actually considering a purchase. That's how we separate creators who drive decisions from those who just drive views.”

CREATIVE WORK

The lives of creators unfold at the intersection of creativity and commerce. Yet for many Gen Z creators, the journey did not begin as a strategic career pivot. Krutika, who gained online fame as The Mermaid Scales, started with outfit posts. “After some time, I started